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Workplace Conduct and Reporting

Educational and synthetic policy corpus. Northstar Technologies Inc. is a fictional company created for an AI engineering project. All people, records, email addresses, examples, and operational data are synthetic. These documents are not legal advice and do not replace applicable law, benefit plan documents, signed employment agreements, or case-specific guidance from People Operations.

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Policy owner	People Operations and Ethics
Approver	Chief People Officer
Applies to	Employees, officers, interns, contractors, applicants, visitors, and others interacting with Northstar personnel or systems
Classification	Internal

CON-1. Purpose and standard

Northstar is committed to a respectful, safe, inclusive, honest, and professional environment. Everyone covered by this policy must treat others with dignity, protect company and personal information, avoid improper conflicts, and report material concerns in good faith.

This policy applies in offices, remote work, business travel, customer sites, online communication, work events, social functions connected to work, and interactions involving company systems or authority.

CON-2. Respectful conduct

Expected conduct includes professional communication, reasonable collaboration, respect for boundaries, constructive disagreement, inclusive participation, and compliance with lawful instructions. A demanding deadline,

informal channel, remote setting, or senior title does not excuse abusive behavior.

Examples of unacceptable conduct include bullying, humiliation, threats, repeated hostile comments, deliberate exclusion used as punishment, sabotage, and misuse of authority. Ordinary feedback, performance management, or respectful disagreement is not misconduct merely because it is uncomfortable.

CON-3. Harassment and discrimination

Harassment, discrimination, and sexual harassment are prohibited on any protected or personal characteristic recognized by applicable law or company policy. Prohibited behavior may be verbal, visual, physical, digital, or sexual and may occur even without intent to offend.

Examples include slurs, degrading jokes, unwanted sexual attention, repeated comments about a person's body or identity, display of offensive material, conditioning work opportunities on personal or sexual conduct, and adverse treatment because a person raised a concern or requested accommodation.

A single severe incident or a pattern of less severe incidents may violate this policy.

CON-4. Retaliation

Retaliation is prohibited against a person who in good faith reports a concern, asks a question, participates in an investigation, requests leave or accommodation, refuses an unlawful instruction, or supports another person.

Retaliation may include termination, demotion, threats, schedule manipulation, exclusion, hostile scrutiny, reduced opportunity, negative references, or social pressure. A good-faith report is protected even when the concern is not substantiated. Knowingly false statements may be addressed separately.

CON-5. Violence, threats, and immediate safety

Violence, credible threats, stalking, intimidation, weapons contrary to law or site rules, and intentional property damage are prohibited. In an immediate danger, contact local emergency services first, move to safety, and then notify Security or People Operations when possible.

Do not use an ordinary HR case or AI assistant as the only response to an emergency.

CON-6. Conflicts of interest and outside activity

Employees must disclose an actual or potential conflict, including a financial interest in a supplier or customer, outside work that competes or interferes, supervision of a close personal relationship, or participation in a decision affecting a related person.

Disclosure does not automatically prohibit the activity. Northstar may approve safeguards, change decision authority, or determine that the conflict cannot be managed. Employees must not use confidential information, company time, equipment, or position for improper personal benefit.

CON-7. Gifts, entertainment, and improper influence

Gifts or entertainment must be modest, infrequent, lawful, transparent, and consistent with **POL-EXP-001**. Cash or cash equivalents are prohibited. Anything intended to influence a decision, reward improper conduct, or create an obligation must not be offered or accepted.

Government, healthcare, education, and regulated-sector interactions may require Legal or Compliance review even below ordinary limits.

CON-8. Confidentiality, privacy, and records

Employees must protect Confidential and Restricted information and comply with **POL-SEC-001**. Access is based on role need, not curiosity. Personnel, customer, investigation, payroll, and security information must not be discussed with unauthorized people or placed in public AI tools.

Employees must preserve relevant records when notified of an investigation, audit, legal hold, or security incident. Altering, hiding, or destroying evidence is prohibited.

CON-9. Communication, social media, and public statements

Employees may express personal views, but must not imply company endorsement without authority, disclose non-public information, harass colleagues, or use company branding deceptively. Only authorized spokespersons may make official public statements.

Work communication should remain professional. Recording a meeting requires notice and must comply with law and policy. Managers must not require employees to disclose personal social-media passwords.

CON-10. Substance use and fitness for work

Employees must be fit to perform duties safely and effectively. Possessing, distributing, or working while impaired by unlawful drugs or misused substances is prohibited. Lawful medication or disability-related needs should be discussed confidentially with People Operations when they may affect safety or require accommodation.

Alcohol may be served at an approved event, but participation is optional and standards of conduct remain in force.

CON-11. Reporting channels

A concern may be raised through any appropriate channel:

- a manager or next-level manager;
- People Operations through the case portal or `peopleops@northstar.example`;
- Ethics through `ethics@northstar.example`;
- Information Security for security incidents; or
- local emergency services for immediate danger.

A reporter may request confidentiality or use an available anonymous channel. Confidentiality cannot be guaranteed because Northstar may need to investigate, protect people, or comply with law. Information will be limited to those with a legitimate need.

CON-12. Manager duty to escalate

A manager who receives or observes a concern involving harassment, discrimination, retaliation, violence, credible threat, serious safety risk, fraud, or material confidentiality breach must notify People Operations, Ethics, or Security within one business day - sooner when risk is urgent. The manager must not promise secrecy, conduct an unauthorized investigation, or require the reporter to confront the subject.

Routine interpersonal issues may be coached locally, but a manager should consult People Operations when classification is uncertain.

CON-13. Investigation and fair process

Northstar will assess concerns promptly and impartially. An investigation may include interviews, documents, system records, and other relevant evidence. Participants must cooperate honestly and preserve confidentiality to the extent possible.

The subject of a concern will receive a fair opportunity to respond, consistent with safety, privacy, and investigative integrity. Northstar may use interim measures such as reporting-line changes, access restrictions, schedule changes, or paid leave. Interim measures are not findings of misconduct.

CON-14. Outcomes and corrective action

When a concern is substantiated, action may include coaching, training, process changes, warning, reassignment, loss of access, contract action, termination, restitution, or external referral. Outcomes are based on severity, intent, impact, history, consistency, and legal obligations.

Reporters and witnesses may be told that the matter was addressed, but privacy may prevent disclosure of detailed discipline.

CON-15. Examples

- A manager who receives a harassment complaint must escalate it within one business day and should not attempt a private settlement.
- An employee may disclose a supplier family relationship and be removed from the selection decision without being accused of wrongdoing.
- Repeatedly excluding an employee from essential meetings after the employee reported misconduct may be retaliation.
- An immediate threat of violence requires emergency and Security action, not only a standard HR ticket.

Related policies and records

- **POL-HRC-001 - HR Case Management and Escalation**
- **POL-SEC-001 - Information Security for Remote Workers**
- **POL-EXP-001 - Business Expenses and Reimbursements**
- **POL-LEV-001 - Statutory, Medical, and Personal Leave**